Syllabus

KLEIN, SUPERINTENDENT, DEPARTMENT OF DETENTION FACILITIES FOR ANNE ARUNDEL COUNTY, ET AL. *v.* MARTIN

ON PETITION FOR WRIT OF CERTIORARI TO THE UNITED STATES COURT OF APPEALS FOR THE FOURTH CIRCUIT

No. 25–51. Decided January 26, 2026

Respondent Charles Brandon Martin was convicted in a Maryland court for the attempted murder of one of his girlfriends, who was found unconscious in her apartment with a gunshot wound to the head. Three items found at the crime scene played a key part in the State's case: a shell casing and bullet from a .380-caliber cartridge and a peculiarly modified Gatorade bottle resembling a homemade silencer. Federal firearms records showed that Martin owned a .380-caliber semiautomatic handgun that could have fired the bullet and ejected the casing. As for the bottle, testing revealed DNA evidence that strongly implicated Martin, and a witness testified that, shortly before the shooting, Martin was in a room with a Gatorade bottle and the same kind of tape that was found on the bottle at the crime scene. In addition, Sheri Carter, another of Martin's girlfriends, testified that Martin had used a laptop at her home in 2008 to research homemade gun silencers before the shooting. The jury found Martin guilty as an accessory before the fact, and he was sentenced to life in prison; his conviction was affirmed on direct appeal. Martin sought postconviction relief in state court, arguing that the State violated his right to due process by failing to disclose a forensic report analyzing computers found at his home, including a laptop from a former employer. The report found no evidence that the laptop had been used since 2005, and it noted that keyword searches for terms like "silencer" and "homemade silencer" yielded no hits. Martin argued that this computer was the one about which Carter testified and that the report tended to discredit her testimony. The postconviction court agreed and ordered a new trial, but a unanimous panel of the Maryland Court of Special Appeals reversed on the ground that the report was not material. Martin sought habeas relief in federal court, and the District Court granted his petition based on the State's failure to disclose the forensic report. A sharply divided panel of the Fourth Circuit affirmed.

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Held: Because the state appellate court's decision—that the undisclosed forensic report was not material under *Brady* v. *Maryland*, 373 U. S. 83—neither was "contrary to" nor "involved an unreasonable applica-